The Role of the Parliament of Tanzania in Combating Human Trafficking

Speech by the Speaker of the Parliament of the United Republic of Tanzania | Inter-Parliamentary Union

Madam President of the Inter-Parliamentary Union, Honourable Speakers, distinguished parliamentarians, ladies and gentlemen:

I thank the Inter-Parliamentary Union for bringing us together. Human trafficking is an assault on human dignity, freedom and the promise of a better life. It turns people into instruments of another person's profit. Behind every case is a human being: a child separated from safety, a woman deceived by a false offer of work, or a family whose trust has been exploited.

Tanzania is not immune. Our country is a place of origin, transit and destination for trafficking. The latest United States Trafficking in Persons Report, covering April 2024 to March 2025, records that the Government identified 33 victims: 20 children and 13 adults. Twenty were Tanzanian citizens and 13 were Burundian nationals. Civil society and international organisations reported identifying a further 94 people. These figures are not a national prevalence estimate, and the two reporting streams must not be added as though they were one complete count. They do, however, remind us that no official tally captures every person who has endured exploitation.

The same report records seven investigations, prosecution of ten defendants, and four convictions during that period. It also notes the absence of a centralised law-enforcement database and continuing gaps in victim screening and services. The pattern includes internal exploitation and cross-border movement; forced labour in domestic work, agriculture and mining; sexual exploitation; and deceptive recruitment through online job advertisements and social media. Poverty, limited livelihood options, gender inequality and unsafe migration can heighten exposure. They never diminish the responsibility of the trafficker.

Tanzania has acted through law. The Anti-Trafficking in Persons Act, 2008 applies to Mainland Tanzania and Zanzibar and establishes offences, victim protections and a fund. Parliament strengthened this framework through the Written Laws (Miscellaneous Amendments) (No. 2) Act, 2024. The amendment established the Anti-Trafficking in Persons Secretariat and set out its functions. The current consolidated Act directs it to "identify, rescue, protect, rehabilitate and reintegrate victims of trafficking in persons." That is a practical mandate: to connect prevention, investigation, safe accommodation and recovery.

Parliament's committees can make this accountability continuous: by examining ministerial estimates and performance reports, following up on unanswered questions, and comparing announced programmes with services actually available in districts and communities. The 2024 amendment was not merely a declaration of concern; it placed coordination, research and victim support within a statutory institution. Our duty is to ensure that institutional promise becomes visible protection for people at risk.

Our constitutional responsibilities do not end when a law is passed. Parliament must examine whether the law is implemented, whether ministries and enforcement agencies coordinate, and whether appropriated resources reach the work for which they were intended. We must scrutinise results: Are cases identified early? Are recruiters regulated? Are investigations completed and prosecutions supported by evidence? Do victims receive protection without being punished for acts compelled by their exploitation? Can a survivor recover, return safely and rebuild a life?

As representatives of our people, we must also listen to communities most exposed to deceptive recruitment and exploitation, and insist on clear public information about safe employment and migration. Budget scrutiny must weigh not only enforcement, but also trained front-line officers, victim-centred services, shelters, counselling, rehabilitation and reintegration. The 2025 assessment reports increased national funding and investment in three new shelters—important steps whose delivery and sustained operation merit continued parliamentary oversight.

We should be candid about the distance between the legal framework and daily experience. The latest assessment describes uneven use of victim-identification procedures, reliance on civil society for many services, limited victim-witness assistance and coordination challenges. It also identifies the need for stronger oversight of recruitment agencies and better support for Tanzanians employed abroad. The creation of a Secretariat is an opportunity; its effectiveness will depend on staffing, resources, reliable data and accountability across Mainland Tanzania and Zanzibar.

The Palermo Protocol names cooperation among States Parties as one of its purposes. For parliaments, that means more than exchanging resolutions: it means supporting practical channels for evidence-sharing, lawful mutual assistance and safe referral when victims cross borders. It also means learning from survivors and civil society, whose knowledge can help us design responses that are humane, trusted and effective.

Human trafficking crosses borders, but protection must begin where a person is found. I therefore invite our fellow parliaments to cooperate in ways that make a difference: harmonise laws with international commitments, share

timely information, support lawful cross-border investigations, scrutinise recruitment chains and protect the rights of victims throughout proceedings. We must also ensure that new technologies serve prevention and detection, rather than becoming instruments of deception and control.

Tanzania is party to the Palermo Protocol, and our domestic law places responsibility on national institutions to act. Parliament can help turn these commitments into measurable progress by asking the difficult questions, following the money, listening to survivors and communities, and acting together across political and national boundaries. No person should be bought, sold or treated as a commodity. Let us make that principle visible in our laws, our budgets and our practice. In solidarity, let us strengthen the parliamentary effort until every person can live and work in freedom and dignity. I thank you.